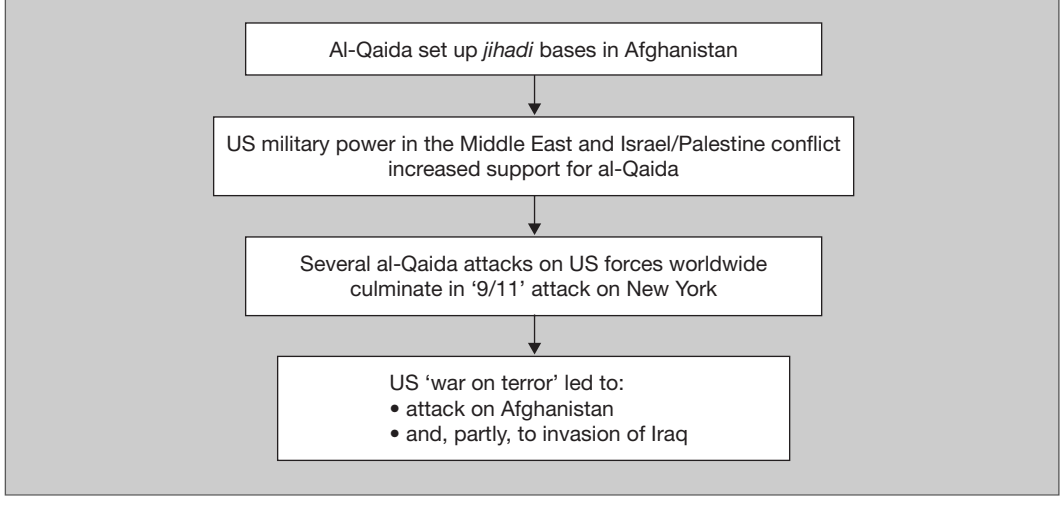
Key dates

US attack on Afghanistan: October 2001

US invasion of Iraq: 2003

The US government took stock before launching its 'war on terror'. President Bush was quick to proclaim that Islam was a great and peaceful religion and he visited American mosques to show his support for American Muslims. Then, in October, US forces attacked Afghanistan and overthrew the Taliban government that had provided a safe haven for al-Qaida. They did not catch Bin Laden who was quick to taunt Bush for failing to destroy him: he did this in a video message broadcast on the Arabic satellite television channel, al-Jazeera. Al-Qaida later took responsibility for the bombing of Madrid railway station, which killed 191 people in 2004, and for the London bombings in 2005, which killed 52. (While al-Qaida might have inspired the London bombings it is not thought that al-Qaida operatives organised them.)

When US forces drove Iraqi forces out of Kuwait in 1991, they had much support in the Arab world. But when the USA invaded Iraq in 2003, their 'war on terror' was seen by many in the Middle East as a war on Islam, especially when Bush declared that 'you're either with us or against us'. Meanwhile, Israeli tanks moved into the West Bank (see page 103) to crush the Palestinian *Intifada*. The subsequent mass protests that took place in many parts of the Arab world shook the Arab governments that were linked to the USA. Today, the 'Palestinian problem', what Muslims see as the injustice suffered by the Palestinians, remains at the heart of the conflict in the Middle East (see page 108).

For most people in the West, the world changed on 11 September 2001. Westerners could no longer assume that events in the Middle East did not concern them. What happens in Gaza or on the West Bank, in Iraq or in Afghanistan today is likely to affect people in the West tomorrow. What many Muslims see as the West's occupation of Muslim lands has given rise to terrorism both within the Middle East and in the wider world.

Summary diagram: Al-Qaida and the globalisation of terror